Claims desk notes: water damage intake

Ardenfield Mutual, Claims desk. Internal: for claims handlers. owner, version and review date are not set.

These notes are the desk's working checklist for a new homeowners **water damage** claim, from the claim form to a registered claim in ClaimCore with the right next step. Storm, fire and theft claims are not covered here.

Before you start

- Claim forms come in to the **shared mailbox**, or a colleague fills one in for a policyholder who phoned.
- Every claim needs a completed **Home Claim Notification Form** (Policy Wording §6.3).
- Pick up forms in the order they arrived.

1. Read the form

Have these in front of you before you open ClaimCore:

- [ ] Claim form ref (`CF-...`), printed at the top of the form
- [ ] Policy number (`HO-...`)
- [ ] Policyholder name, phone, email and the address of the insured property
- [ ] Date and time of the loss
- [ ] Peril: **Water damage** ticked
- [ ] Cause, where in the home, and what happened
- [ ] Estimated amount (EUR)
- [ ] Signature and date

> **Desk tip:** the policy number and the dates are where re-keying goes wrong. Read them twice.

2. Check the policy in ClaimCore

Open **Policies**, search by the policy number, and open the policy.

- [ ] **Status is Active.** A Lapsed policy can't take a claim.
- [ ] **The date of loss** is not in the future and falls inside the policy period.
- [ ] **Product and deductible:** Homeowners Standard EUR 250, Homeowners Plus EUR 500 per claim (§5.1).
- [ ] **Limits:** note the dwelling limit and the contents limit on the schedule.
- [ ] **Claim history:** look for earlier claims on the same policy (see step 5).

If the policy can't be found, is Lapsed, or the date of loss doesn't fit, ClaimCore won't register the claim. Don't force it: record the reason so the policyholder can be contacted.

3. Read the wording for this loss

Open the **Homeowners Policy Wording** (the **Policy wording** link on the policy page) and find the clause that fits.

- **§3.1 Escape of water:** sudden and accidental escape of water from fixed installations or appliances: a burst pipe (including one that froze), a split or detached hose on a dishwasher or washing machine, an appliance that leaks or overflows during a cycle, a tank or cistern that fails or overflows.
- **§4.3 Gradual leakage exclusion:** water leaking or seeping gradually over **14 days or more**, from any source. That includes water past **failed seals or grouting** around a shower, shower tray, bath, sink or toilet, slow leaks from pipes, joints or fittings, and the rot, mould or subfloor damage that follows.
- **§6.1 Report within 30 days.** A loss reported more than 30 days after it happened is **not** rejected at the desk. Note §6.1 and refer it to an adjuster.

> **Desk tip:** the date the damage was **discovered** is not the date the leak **started** (§4.3). Soft floors, rot, mould, staining, or a contractor saying "weeks" or "months" all point to §4.3. Don't decide it yourself: write down what you saw and refer it.

4. Register the claim (New claim wizard)

Step	What to enter
1. Policy	Search the policy number, check the policy card, tick **Confirm this policy**
2. Loss details	Date of loss, time, peril, cause, location, and a description of **at least 20 characters**
3. Amount	Estimated amount (EUR), contact phone, claim form ref. The attachment is optional
4. Review	Read the summary, tick the declaration, **Submit**

- [ ] ClaimCore shows the new claim number, `CLM-` and six digits, with the status **Registered**.

- [ ] The estimated amount must be between 1 and 1,000,000, or ClaimCore refuses it.
- Claims are registered on the ClaimCore screens only. There is no other way in.

5. Decide the next step

Refer to an adjuster if either of these is true:

- [ ] The estimated amount is **over EUR 5,000** (the auto-approve threshold).
- [ ] The loss **doesn't look clearly covered** under the wording (for example §4.3 might apply).

Either one is enough. If **neither** is true, the claim can be accepted straight away.

Send to fraud review if:

- [ ] The same policy has another claim with a loss date **within 30 days** of this one's (the 30-day window:). Claims on the same policy for similar losses close together in time may be referred for review (§18.3).

Only an **adjuster** decides a referred claim: accept, accept part of it, or deny. Only a **fraud reviewer** rejects a suspected duplicate (that the fraud reviewer is a separate role). The desk never denies a claim.

> **Desk tip:** the threshold is EUR 5,000. Check it on the form every time; don't go by memory.

6. Write the note

On the claim page, add a note that says **why**:

- [ ] the amount against the threshold, if that is the reason
- [ ] the clause you relied on (for example §3.1 or §4.3), and what on the form made you think so
- [ ] for a suspected duplicate, the earlier claim number

> **Desk tip:** a referral with no written reason means the adjuster reads the form and the wording again from scratch.

Referred claims are a **same-day** sign-off: an adjuster picks them up the day they are referred.

Claim statuses you will see

Status	Meaning
Registered	The claim exists in ClaimCore
In triage	The claim is being assessed
Referred to adjuster	Waiting for the adjuster
Accepted	Accepted straight away, or by the adjuster
Partially accepted	The adjuster accepted part of the claim
Denied	The adjuster denied the claim
Rejected (duplicate)	The fraud reviewer confirmed a duplicate

Busy days

Cold snaps bring burst pipes and up to three times the usual number of claims.